comparative study of the nominees' qualifications (Article 28 of the OPEC Statute). In the absence of a unanimous decision, the Secretary-General is appointed on a rotation basis for a term of two years, without prejudice to the required qualifications.

The Secretary-General is assisted in the discharge of his duties by the Research Division, the Administration and the Human Resources Department, the Public Relations and Information Department, and by his own Office. The Senior Legal Counsel provides legal advice to the Secretary-General, supervises the Secretariat's legal and contractual affairs, and evaluates the legal issues of concern to the Organization and the member countries, and recommends appropriate action.

The office of the Secretary-General provides him with executive assistance, particularly in establishing and maintaining contacts with governments, organizations and delegations in matters of protocol, in the preparation for and coordination of meetings, and in carrying out any other duties assigned by the Secretary-General.

This regional organization came into prominence during the 1970s, in the backdrop of the Arab–Israeli conflict and marked the beginning of oil diplomacy. The Yom Kippur War of 1973 resulted in a strong Arab opinion against the West. It prompted the OPEC to initiate an embargo against all the states supporting Israel. The rise of Iranian nationalism and the series of clashes with Israel in 1946 and in early 1970s induced the Arab leaders to make use of oil as a weapon to teach the West a lesson. When the United States and the West European states began to supply Israel with huge quantities of arms, which helped them to withstand Egyptian and Syrian forces, the Arab world was infuriated and they imposed the 1973 oil embargo against the United States and the Western Europe. OPEC realized its potential and the significance of oil as a weapon and, thereafter, raised the price of oil per barrel. Finally, long-term price levels were normalized due to the pressure of Saudi Arabia, the richest member of OPEC. The West had learnt a lesson from this crisis.

It is from this time onwards that the OPEC rose to international prominence and it acquired a major say in the pricing of crude oil in the world markets. Under such circumstances, the First Summit of